

DEPART MENTS OF FASHION DESIGNN AND MARKETING

HFD 108 FASHION FIGURE DRAWING (NOTES)

SEMESTER 2, 2026/2027

Fashion illustration is a form of art used to visually communicate clothing, accessories, and overall style concepts. It's commonly used by designers, stylists, and brands to present ideas before garments are actually made.

Key features of fashion illustration:

- Focus on clothing and style: The main goal is to highlight the design, fabric, colors, and movement of an outfit.
- Stylized human figures: Figures are often elongated or exaggerated (not realistic proportions) to emphasize elegance and flow.
- Creative expression: Illustrators use different techniques like watercolor, ink, digital drawing, or mixed media to convey mood and personality.
- Used in the fashion industry: From early design sketches to magazine editorials and marketing visuals.

Where you'll see it:

- Designer sketchbooks
- Fashion magazines and ads
- Runway concept presentations
- Social media and branding visuals

Figure 1 below shows Fashion illustrations by famous designer:



René Gruau – known
for bold, elegant



David Downton –
famous for modern,



Antonio Lopez –
influential in the 1970s

Fig: 1

In simple terms, fashion illustration is like the visual language of fashion ideas—it brings clothing concepts to life before they exist physically.

Topic 1. The 9-head proportion

The **9-head proportion** is a guideline used in **fashion illustration** to draw the human figure taller and more elegant than real-life proportions.

What it means:

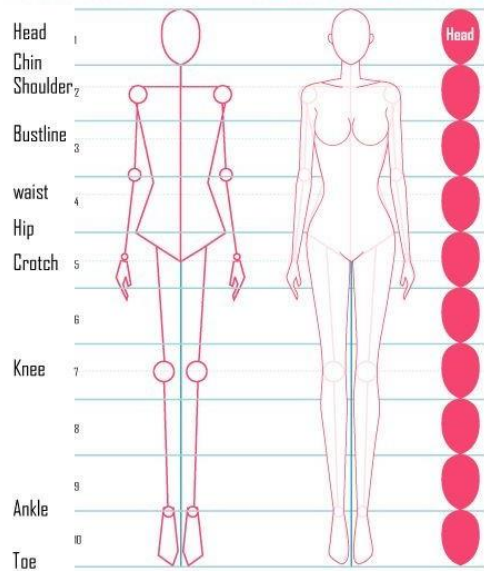
In this system, the **height of the entire body equals 9 “heads” stacked vertically** (using the head as a unit of measurement).

- In real life, an average person is about **7–8 heads tall**
- In fashion illustration, artists extend it to **9 heads** to create a more **stylized, elongated, and graceful look**

How the 9 heads are divided:

1. **Head 1** – Top of the head to chin
2. **Head 2** – Neck and upper chest
3. **Head 3** – Bust area
4. **Head 4** – Waist
5. **Head 5** – Hips/crotch area
6. **Head 6** – Mid-thigh
7. **Head 7** – Knees
8. **Head 8** – Calves
9. **Head 9** – Ankles to feet

Figure 2 below shows a breakdown from top to bottom:



Fig; 2: 9 heads proportion

Why it' used:

- Makes designs look more **high-fashion and elegant**
- Gives more space to showcase **clothing details**
- Creates a **runway-model appearance**

Topic 2. Poses in fashion

Poses in fashion refer to the different **ways a model stands, moves, or positions their body** to showcase clothing, style, and attitude in photos, illustrations, or runway shows.

They are important because the **pose can change how an outfit looks**—highlighting fit, movement, and mood.

Why poses matter in fashion

- Show the **shape and structure** of clothing
- Add **personality and emotion**
- Make designs look more **dynamic and stylish**
- Help attract attention in photos, posters, and illustrations

Common types of fashion poses

1. Standing pose

- Simple and straight posture
- Focuses on the outfit clearly
- Often used in catalog or basic fashion sketches \

Figure 3 below shows standing pose.

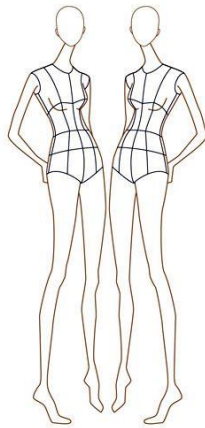


Fig: 3

2. Contrapposto pose/ “S’ Shape

- Body weight shifted to one leg
- Creates an **S-curve** in the body
- Makes the pose look natural and elegant

Figure 4 below shows an S shape pose

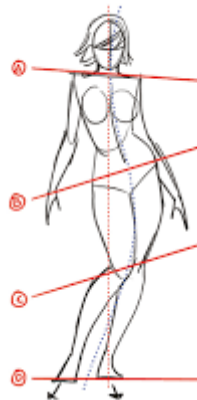


Fig: 4

Others poses

3. Walking pose

- One leg forward, arms slightly moving
- Gives a **runway feel** like in *New York Fashion Week*

- Shows how clothes move

4. Sitting pose

- Model sits on a chair, floor, or object
- Creates a relaxed or editorial look
- Good for storytelling

5. Action pose

- Jumping, turning, or dramatic movement
- Adds energy and excitement
- Often used in modern campaigns like those by Nike

6. Hand-on-hip pose

- Classic confident pose
- Highlights the waist and body shape

7. Over-the-shoulder pose

- Model looks back over shoulder
- Adds mystery and elegance

Factors to consider while illustrating fashion poses

- Keep the body **elongated** (especially in fashion illustration)
- Avoid stiffness add a slight **curve or tilt**
- Think about **what part of the outfit you want to highlight**
- Practice using references from magazines or brands like Vogue

Simple idea to remember:

A good fashion pose is not just standing it's **telling a story with the body while showing the clothes.**

Topic 3. Facial Features (The Face)

a) Proportions

- The face is typically divided into **three equal parts**:
 1. Hairline → Eyebrows
 2. Eyebrows → Bottom of nose
 3. Nose → Chin
- Eyes are usually placed **halfway down the head.**
- The distance between the eyes $\approx$ **one eye width.**

- Lips sit about **one-third of the way** between the nose and chin.

b) Eyes

- Fashion illustrations often **stylize eyes** (larger, elongated, or simplified).
- Focus on **eyelashes and eyeliner** to add drama rather than full realism.

c) Nose

- Often simplified in fashion sketches.
- Can be indicated with **minimal lines or shading**, rather than detailed structure.

d) Lips

- Usually emphasized for expression and style.
- The upper lip is often **darker** than the lower lip due to shadow.

e) Hairstyles

- Draw hair as **large shapes first**, then add strands.
- Consider:
 - Volume (not flat on the scalp)
 - Flow and movement
 - Texture (curly, straight, braided, etc.)
- Avoid drawing every strand focus on **form and direction**.

Figure 5 below shows coquis facial features and placement

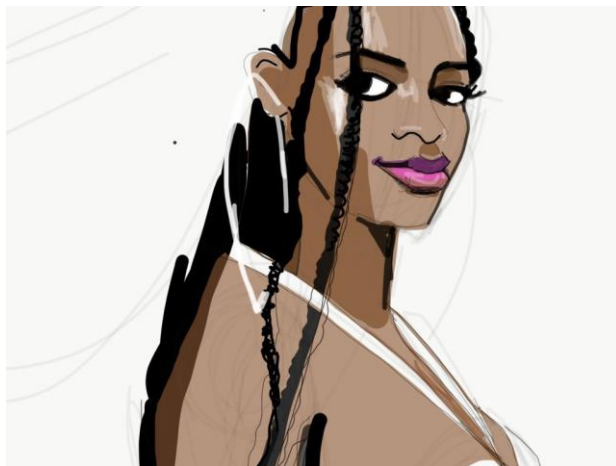
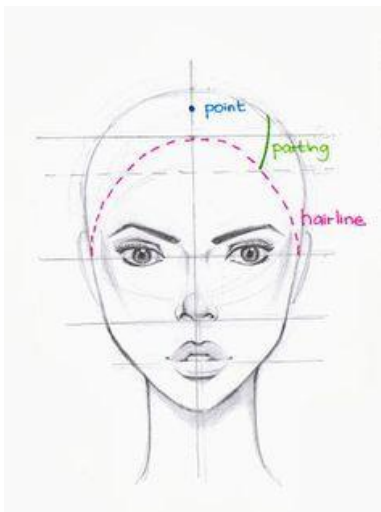


Figure 5

Topic 4. Hands and feet

In fashion illustration, hands are best approached by simplifying their structure into basic forms. The palm can be sketched as a block or rectangle, while the fingers are represented as cylinders to establish proportion and direction. Attention should be given to natural anatomy, such as the relative length of fingers where the middle finger is typically the longest—and the gentle curve of the knuckles rather than a rigid straight line. Gesture drawing is essential for capturing fluid, expressive hand poses, allowing the illustrator to convey movement and elegance. In most fashion sketches, details are intentionally minimized, with the focus placed on suggesting the form rather than rendering every anatomical feature.

When drawing feet, begin with a triangular or wedge-like shape to establish the overall structure, then add toes as simplified forms to avoid unnecessary detail. It is important to consider the angle of the foot and how weight is distributed, especially in posed figures. Shoe illustration builds on this foundation, requiring an understanding of different styles and their visual characteristics. Heels tend to elongate the foot and enhance the leg line, sneakers appear bulkier with rounded forms, and boots emphasize structure and verticality. Across all footwear, attention to perspective is crucial, particularly in dynamic poses, along with key design elements such as laces, soles, and straps that define the shoe's style. **Figure six below shows hands and feet.**

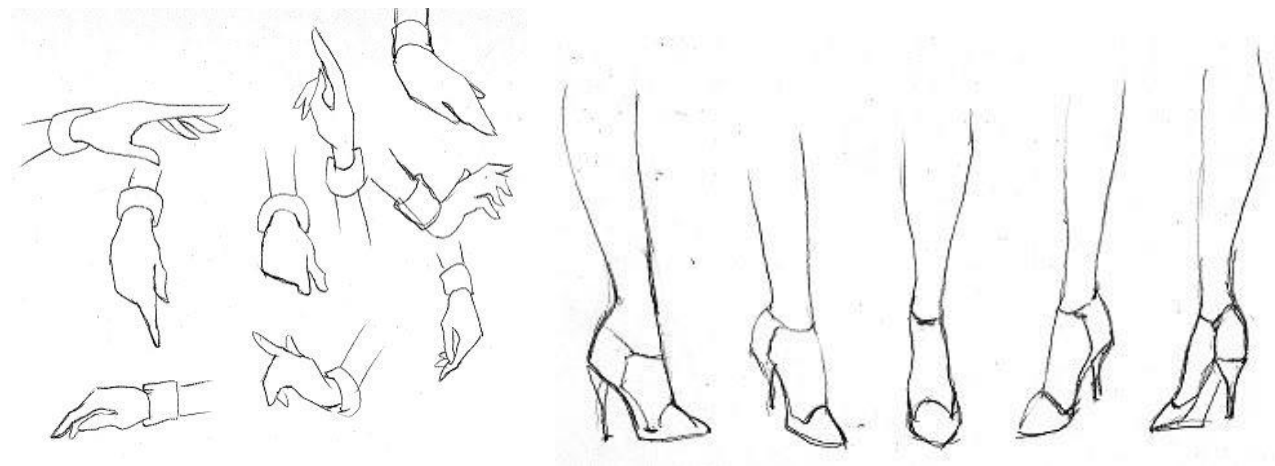


Fig 6

Why hands and feet are difficult to draw

a. **Complex Structure**

Hands and feet have intricate anatomy. Hands contain many bones and joints that allow detailed movement, while feet are built to support body weight and maintain balance, making both challenging to construct accurately.

b. **High Flexibility**

Hands, especially fingers, can bend in many directions. Because of this flexibility, even small mistakes in angles or positioning can look very obvious and unnatural.

c. **Foreshortening Challenges**

when hands or feet are angled toward or away from the viewer, their proportions appear shortened or distorted. Capturing this correctly requires a strong understanding of perspective.

d. **Proportion Sensitivity**

Hands and feet are very sensitive to proportion errors. Slight inaccuracies like overly long fingers or undersized feet can disrupt the realism of the entire figure, especially in stylized fashion drawings.

e. **Expressiveness and Impact**

Hands play a key role in conveying emotion, gesture, and elegance. If they are poorly drawn, they can make the whole illustration feel stiff, awkward, or less convincing.

f. **Lack of Practice**

many beginners avoid drawing hands and feet because they are difficult. This leads to less practice, which makes improving these areas even more challenging over time.

Quick tips

- Practice drawing hands in **different poses daily**.
- Use references (photos or your own hands).
- Break forms into **simple shapes first**.
- Focus on **gesture before detail**.

Topic 5 Garment Silhouettes

1. Garment Silhouettes

A **silhouette** refers to the overall shape or outline of a garment. It is the first visual impression and defines style, proportion, and fit.

Common Silhouettes:

- **Straight (Column):** Falls vertically from shoulders; minimal shaping (e.g., shift dress).
- **A-line:** Fitted at the top, gradually widens toward the hem.
- **Hourglass (Fitted):** Emphasizes waist with balanced bust and hips.
- **Empire:** Raised waistline just below the bust with a flowing lower section.
- **Mermaid:** Fitted through body, flares dramatically at or below the knee.
- **Oversized/Boxy:** Loose, wide proportions with minimal body definition.

Key Considerations:

- Body proportions and balance
- Fabric behavior (drape, stiffness)
- Function (formal, casual, activewear)

2. Garment Construction

Garment construction is the process of assembling fabric into a finished piece using technical methods.

Basic Construction Elements:

- **Seams:** Join fabric pieces (plain, French, overlocked).
- **Darts:** Shape fabric to fit body contours.
- **Pleats & Gathers:** Add fullness and movement.
- **Facings & Interfacing:** Provide structure and finishing.
- **Closures:** Zippers, buttons, hooks for functionality.
- **Hems:** Finish garment edges neatly.

Topic 6 Fashion Flats

Fashion flats are technical drawings of garments shown without a figure, used to communicate design details clearly.

Characteristics:

- Clean, accurate, and proportional
- Usually drawn in black and white
- Show front and back views
- Focus on construction details (seams, stitching, trims)

Purpose:

- Used in production and manufacturing
- Communicate ideas to pattern makers and manufacturers
- Provide a visual specification of the garment

Key Elements to Include:

- Garment outline (based on silhouette)
- Stitch lines and seam placement
- Details (pockets, collars, cuffs, closures)
- Fabric indication (optional texture lines)

Conclusion

Understanding **silhouettes** helps define garment shape, **construction** ensures functionality and durability, while **fashion flats** communicate the design precisely for production. Together, they form the foundation of effective fashion design and garment development.

Topic 7 Fabric Draping & Folds

1. Definition & Purpose

Fabric draping is the way a textile hangs and conforms to the body or form under gravity. It influences silhouette, movement, and emotional expression in a garment. Folds are the visible formations created when fabric bends, gathers, or collapses key to adding volume, rhythm, and texture.

2. Factors Affecting Drape

- **Fiber Content:** Natural fibers (silk, wool) drape softly; synthetics (polyester, nylon) can be structured or fluid depending on weave.
- **Fabric Weight:** Light fabrics (chiffon) flow; heavy fabrics (denim) hold shape.
- **Weave/Structure:** Loose weaves drape better than tight, rigid constructions.
- **Finish & Treatment:** Washing, pleating, or coating alters drape behavior.
- **Bias Cut:** Cutting fabric at 45° increases stretch and fluidity.

3. Types of Drapes

- **Soft/Fluid Drape:** Flows naturally (e.g., silk gowns).
- **Structured/Stiff Drape:** Holds form (e.g., tailored jackets).
- **Controlled Drape:** Manipulated using darts, seams, or gathers.
- **Natural Drape:** Falls freely without construction interference.

4. Types of Folds

- **Pipe Folds:** Long, rounded, vertical folds (common in draped dresses).
- **Knife Pleats:** Sharp, uniform folds in one direction.
- **Box Pleats:** Symmetrical folds creating volume.
- **Inverted Pleats:** Folded inward, often used in skirts.
- **Gathered Folds:** Soft, irregular folds formed by drawing fabric together.
- **Draped Folds:** Organic, asymmetrical folds created directly on a dress form.

5. Draping Techniques

- **On Dress Form (3D Draping):** Pinning fabric directly onto a mannequin to develop design.
- **Twisting & Knotting:** Adds dynamic surface interest.
- **Pleating & Gathering:** Controls fullness and distribution.
- **Layering:** Creates depth and complex silhouettes.
- **Tucking & Folding:** Builds structure and decorative detail.

Key Insight:

Mastery of draping and folds transforms flat fabric into expressive, three-dimensional fashion bridging technical construction with artistic design.

Topic 8 Rendering Textures (Black & White)

1. Definition & Purpose

Rendering textures in black and white is the technique of representing fabric surfaces, depth, and material qualities using only tonal variation (light, mid-tones, darks) without color. It enhances realism, communicates fabric type, and clarifies construction details in fashion illustration.

2. Core Principles

- **Value (Tone):** The foundation use a full range from highlights to deep shadows to show form and texture.
- **Light Source:** Establish a consistent direction; it determines where highlights and shadows fall.
- **Contrast:** High contrast for glossy/smooth fabrics; low contrast for soft/matte surfaces.
- **Line Quality:** Vary line weight (thick/thin, sharp/soft) to suggest texture and depth.

3. Common Techniques

- **Hatching:** Parallel lines to build tone and direction.
- **Cross-Hatching:** Layered intersecting lines for deeper shadows.
- **Stippling:** Dots to create soft, grainy textures.
- **Scumbling:** Loose, scribbled marks for irregular surfaces.
- **Blending/Smudging:** Smooth transitions for soft fabrics.
- **Negative Space:** Leaving white areas to indicate highlights and sheen.

4. Rendering Different Fabric Textures

- **Silk/Satin (Smooth & Shiny):**
 - a. Strong highlights and deep shadows.
 - b. Clean, flowing lines following folds.
 - c. High contrast with sharp edges.
- **Cotton (Soft & Matte):**
 - a. Subtle tonal shifts, low contrast.
 - b. Soft edges and gentle folds.
 - c. Minimal highlights.
- **Wool (Thick & Textured):**

- a. Use short, dense strokes or stippling.
 - b. Emphasize bulk and weight.
 - c. Mid-to-dark tonal range.
- **Denim (Structured & Grainy):**
 - a. Cross-hatching for structure.
 - b. Add seam lines and stitch details.
 - c. Moderate contrast.
- **Leather (Smooth but Firm):**
 - a. Bold highlights with controlled shading.
 - b. Slight texture using fine grain marks.
 - c. Reflective but less fluid than silk.
- **Sheer Fabrics (e.g., Chiffon):**
 - a. Very light shading.
 - b. Overlapping lines to suggest transparency.
 - c. Show underlying form faintly.

5. Rendering Folds in B/W

- Use **graduated tones** to show depth within folds.
- Darkest areas occur in **fold creases and overlaps**.
- Highlights sit on **raised ridges**.
- Follow the **direction of the fold** with your strokes.

6. Tools & Materials

- **Pencils (HB–6B):** Range for light to dark values.
- **Ink Pens/Fineliners:** Precision and strong contrast.
- **Charcoal:** Rich blacks and expressive textures.
- **Blending Tools:** Tissue, stump, or finger for smooth transitions.
- **Eraser:** For lifting highlights and refining texture.

7. Design Considerations

- Match rendering style to **fabric behavior and garment type**.
- Avoid overworking maintain clarity and focus.
- Use texture to support **silhouette and structure**, not overpower it.
- Keep consistency across the entire illustration.

8. Common Mistakes

- Flat shading (lack of tonal variation).
- Ignoring light source direction.
- Overuse of outlines instead of tonal modeling.
- Rendering all fabrics the same way (no differentiation).

9. Practical Tips

- Practice drawing a **value scale** (light to dark) regularly.
- Study real fabrics under light for observation.
- Start light, build layers gradually.
- Combine techniques (e.g., hatching + blending) for richer effects.

Key Insight:

In black-and-white rendering, texture is communicated through tone, mark-making, and light not color making precision in value control essential for convincing and expressive fashion illustrations.